

SESSION 06

Spread Composition and Grid Breaks

Five decisions govern every spread, and when it's earned, breaking the grid is one of them.

Portfolio as Narrative · Building the Grid, Part II

Design for Understanding

Designing for the Reader, Not for Yourself

- A strong portfolio isn't only about what you think matters.
- **It's about** how clearly your story is understood by someone else.
- **Clarity doesn't come from intention alone**, it comes from design.
- To communicate effectively, you need to understand how people see, read, and process visual information.

“Design is not just what it looks like and feels like. Design is how it works.”

— Steve Jobs

WHAT THE READER SEES FIRST

- Dominant image
- Supporting images
- Captions & specs

Primary → secondary → tertiary: the order a reviewer's eye actually follows, whether or not you designed for it.

Learning Objectives

By the end of tonight, you will be able to:

1

Apply principles from visual perception and cognitive science to make more intentional layout decisions.

2

Use hierarchy, grouping, and flow to organize the two spreads you build out tonight.

3

Diagnose layout issues in your own and your classmates' spreads using a structured set of questions.

4

Revise in real time to improve clarity, pacing, and how quickly a reviewer understands what they're looking at.

Eight Reader-Centered Layout Principles

Eight memory tags. Each one compresses a real study in cognitive or perceptual psychology.

Principle	Memory Tag	Helps You...
1. Cognitive Load Theory	Declutter	Focus each spread by reducing distractions
2. Dual Coding Theory	Pair It	Reinforce visuals with concise supporting text
3. Spatial Contiguity	Keep It Together	Place related images and text near each other
4. Gestalt Grouping	Pattern It	Use grouping, alignment, and similarity
5. Visual Hierarchy	Lead the Eye	Guide attention using scale and placement
6. Scanning Patterns	Flow It	Align layout to natural eye movement
7. Information Scent	Signal the Path	Use labels and structure to aid navigation
8. Whitespace	Let It Breathe	Use space to emphasize and clarify

Principle 1 — Cognitive Load Theory (“Declutter”)

Theory Summary

Too much information overwhelms the viewer's working memory (Sweller, 1988). Working memory holds roughly four items at a time, for seconds, not minutes. When a spread overloads it, viewers miss key points and fail to retain the content.

Application

- Focus on one main idea per spread
- Remove visual noise and irrelevant text
- Eliminate decorative elements that don't contribute
- Be ruthless about editing down content

Sweller, J. (1988). Cognitive load during problem solving. Cognitive Science, 12(2), 257–285.

WORKING MEMORY, FULL



Six unlabeled elements exceed working memory's capacity (roughly four items, Cowan 2001).

WORKING MEMORY, ONE IDEA



Principle 2 — Dual Coding Theory (“Pair It”)

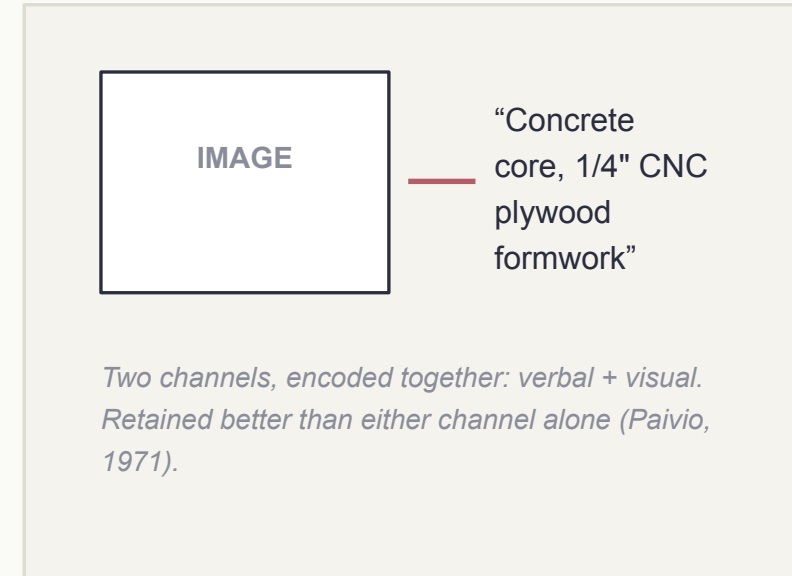
Theory Summary

We process and retain information better when it's presented through both visual and verbal channels (Paivio, 1971). The brain has separate systems for visual and verbal information. Used together, they reinforce each other.

Application

- Combine visuals and text to improve memory
- Use concise captions that reinforce, not repeat
- Break up dense text with supporting imagery
- Label diagrams clearly but minimally

Paivio, A. (1971). Imagery and Verbal Processes. Holt, Rinehart and Winston.



Principle 3 — Spatial Contiguity (“Keep It Together”)

Theory Summary

Learning improves when related words and images are presented near each other rather than separated (Mayer, 2001). The brain spends less effort when it doesn't have to search for and connect related elements.

Application

- Place labels, diagrams, and captions close to what they describe
- Use directional cues like leader lines only when necessary
- Avoid separating explanatory text from its visual
- Create clear visual connections between related items

Mayer, R. E. (2001). Multimedia Learning. Cambridge University Press.

KEEP IT TOGETHER

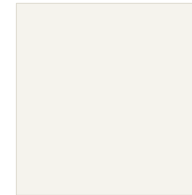


Fig. 1, site section

SEPARATED

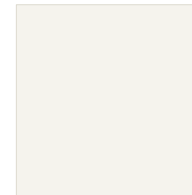


Fig. 1, site section (below, separate legend)

Principle 4 — Gestalt Grouping (“Pattern It”)

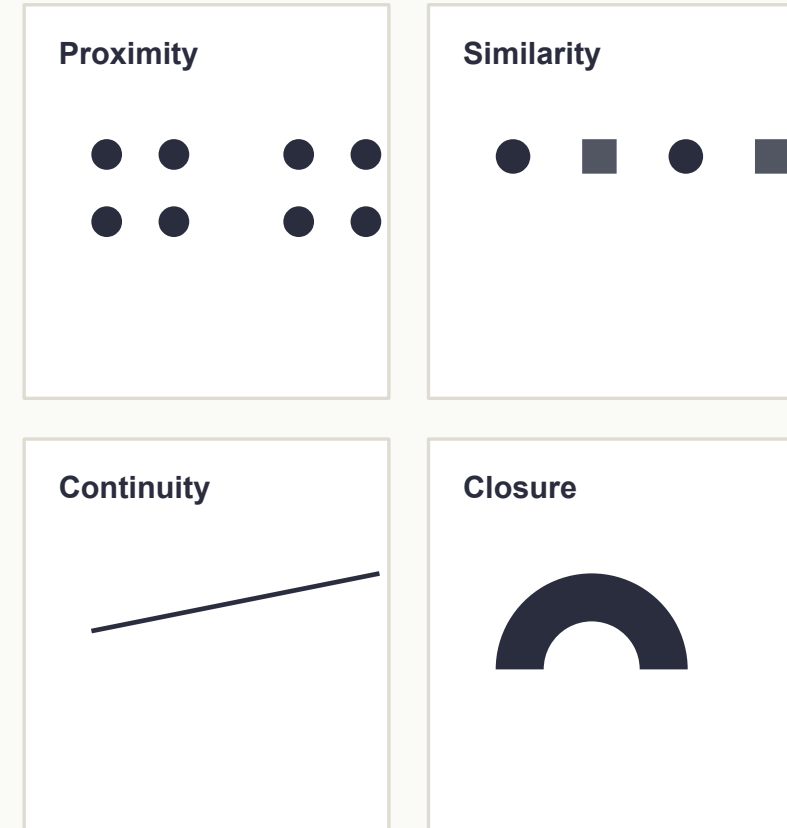
Theory Summary

Viewers naturally perceive and organize visual elements based on patterns of proximity, similarity, continuity, and closure (Koffka, 1935). The brain automatically groups related elements and seeks order in visual information.

Application

- **Proximity:** objects near each other appear related
- **Similarity:** similar items are perceived as a group
- **Continuity:** elements aligned in a pattern appear connected
- **Closure:** we mentally complete incomplete shapes

Koffka, K. (1935). Principles of Gestalt Psychology. Harcourt, Brace and Company.



Principle 5 — Visual Hierarchy (“Lead the Eye”)

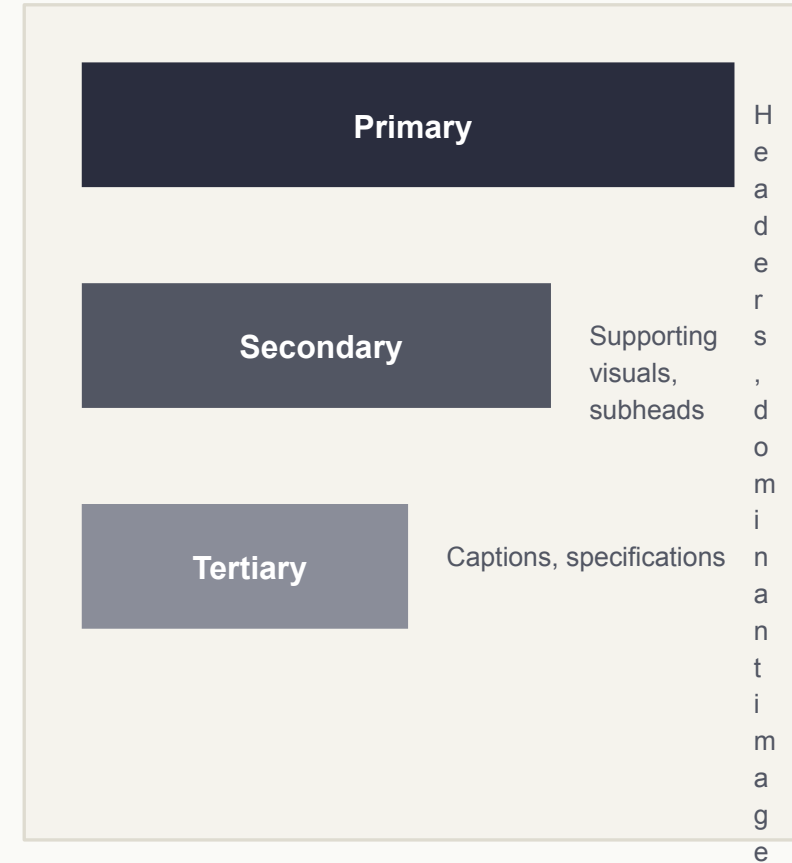
Theory Summary

The brain naturally processes visual information in order of prominence (Lupton, 2004). Deliberate differences in size, weight, and position guide the viewer through your content, primary elements first, tertiary details last.

Application

- **Primary:** headers and key images command attention first
- **Secondary:** supporting visuals and subheadings provide context
- **Tertiary:** captions and specifications add depth
- Position primary elements at entry points, top or left

Lupton, E. (2004). Thinking with Type. Princeton Architectural Press.



Principle 6 — Scanning Patterns (“Flow It”)

Theory Summary

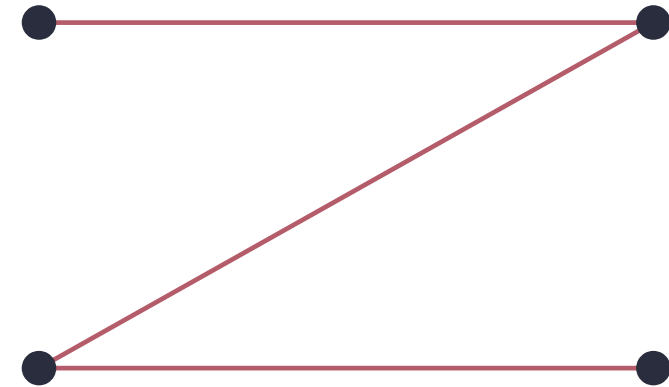
Viewers scan text-heavy pages in an F-shape: across the top, down slightly, across again, then down the left side (Nielsen, 2006). More visual, image-dominant spreads tend toward a Z-path instead. Align your most important content along these natural paths.

Application

- Position titles, key images, and conclusions at the path's terminal points
- A text-heavy spread: expect an F-path
- A visually dominant spread: expect a Z-path
- Test it: trace where your eye actually lands first

Nielsen, J. (2006). F-Shaped Pattern for Reading Web Content. Nielsen Norman Group.

Z-PATTERN, VISUAL SPREADS



Upper left → upper right → diagonally down → lower right. Put your dominant image and title on this path.

Principle 7 — Information Scent (“Signal the Path”)

Theory Summary

Viewers use cues in the environment to predict where to find information and how to navigate content (Pirolli & Card, 1999). Strong “information scent” helps viewers understand content organization and follow your intended narrative.

Application

- Use consistent, descriptive labels and section headers
- Structure your project as: Concept → Process → Design Development → Result
- Use section markers, color tabs, or page numbers to show progression
- Maintain typographic and layout consistency across projects

Pirolli, P., & Card, S. (1999). Information foraging. Psychological Review, 106(4), 643–675.

- 01 Concept Development
- 02 Process
- 03 Design Development

Consistent section markers let a reviewer predict what's next, and decide how much attention to give it.

Principle 8 — Whitespace (“Let It Breathe”)

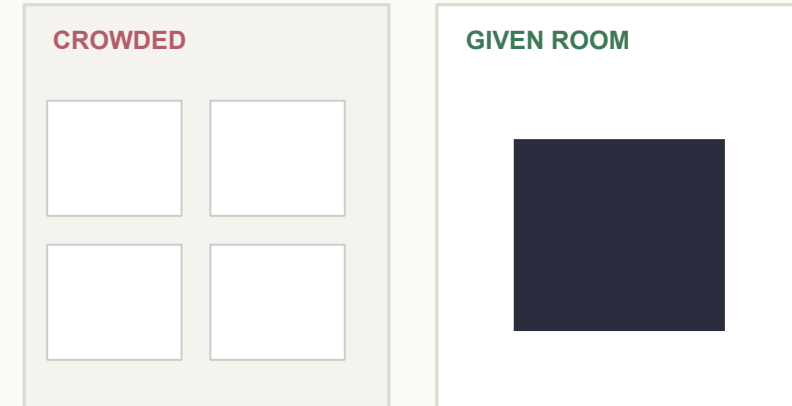
Theory Summary

Space is not empty, it's an active design element that supports comprehension and emphasis (Tufte, 1990). The brain needs visual pauses to process information. Whitespace reduces cognitive load and increases perceived value.

Application

- Use consistent margins around page edges
- Create breathing room between elements
- Allow important elements more surrounding space
- Develop rhythm through alternating dense and open spreads

Tufte, E. R. (1990). Envisioning Information. Graphics Press.



The identical drawing, crowded against three neighbors on the left, given generous margins on the right. Nothing about the drawing changed. Its perceived importance did (Tufte, 1990).

From Principles to Decisions

Every reader-centered principle tonight has a direct counterpart in the five spread decisions.

TONIGHT'S PRINCIPLE		THE SPREAD DECISION IT DRIVES
Visual Hierarchy	→	Dominance
Scanning Patterns	→	Left-Right Relationship
Visual Hierarchy (levels)	→	Image Scaling
Whitespace	→	Whitespace
Spatial Contiguity + Gestalt Grouping	→	Composite Logic

The five decisions are not a separate system. They're what the eight principles look like once you're actually placing content on a page.

Grid Breaks, Earned

The Full-Bleed Image

No margins, no columns, no modules. Works as punctuation: a section divider, a project opener, a closing image. Earn it first, don't open with it.

The Oversized Element

Crosses column or module boundaries to signal hierarchy. Still aligns to column edges, it simply claims more modules than its neighbors.

The Deliberate Void

A title page with a name, a one-line statement, and one image, using the grid's full capacity by choosing to fill only a fraction of it.

The one test: can a reviewer see that the break is intentional? If it looks like an accident, it undermines the argument. If nothing on your spread earns a break tonight, leave the grid intact.

ACTIVITY

Tonight's Activity

Open your real project file from Session 05, the one with your grid, baseline, and paragraph styles already built, and start placing real content into it.

- Two spreads, minimum, with real drawings and renderings, not placeholder boxes
- Name the dominant element on each spread before placing anything else
- Captions placed by spatial contiguity, directly against what they describe
- Consistent labels: a section marker, project title, or page number on each
- A grid break only if a spread has actually earned one

TIMING

35 minutes

Then 20 minutes of small-group peer review using tonight's evaluation questions.

DUE TONIGHT

Your real project file (.indd), two grid-aligned spreads built out with real content, submitted before you leave.

Design for the Reader, Not the Instinct

Eight principles, five decisions, one test for every grid break. None of it replaces a good project. All of it decides whether a reviewer actually sees one.

OPTIONAL READING

“How the Eye Reads a Spread”, the research behind tonight's eight principles.

NEXT SESSION

Session 07: Typography as Architectural Voice